Minerals

South America is rich in minerals. These mineral deposits are unevenly distributed. South America has many valuable deposits of minerals particularly of iron ore, manganese, petroleum, copper and bauxite. There are some active mines producing silver and gold. The continent has little coal which is still one of the mainstays of industrial economies. Northern Chile has the world's only natural deposits of sodium nitrate an important ingredient of fertilizers.

Iron ore

South America contains about one fifth of the world's iron ore reserves. Brazil and Chile both have massive deposits of iron ore. Brazil has the second largest iron ore deposits in the world after Russia. Brazil is estimated to have about 15% of the world export of iron ore. High grade iron ore has long been mined at Itabira, Minas Gerais and new site in the Carajas.

Manganese

Brazil also has large deposits of Manganese. Manganese ore is mined at Lafaiete, Minas Gerais and in the Northern State of Amapa.

Petroleum

Venezuela is rich in petroleum deposits. Argentina, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, Chile and Bolivia are the other valuable oilfields. Petroleum is the only mineral produced in substantial quantity. Argentina is almost self-sufficient in petroleum. Venezuela is one of the world's leading producers of oil and largest oil exporter outside the Middle East.

Copper

Chile is the third largest producer of copper in the world. Copper provides over 40% of exports by value. Some of the biggest copper mines of the world are located in Peru. It is found in the Atacama Desert.

Bauxite

Brazil is the third largest bauxite producing country. An important bauxite mining centre is located near the mouth of the Amazon River. Bauxite is used for aluminum production.

Industries

Industries in South America have developed slowly Argentina, Brazil and Chile are the most highly developed industrial countries in this continent. Until World War I, the continent exported most of its mining production and large amount of minerals particularly Petroleum, Copper and iron are still exported. The continent lacks infrastructure (especially transport) which is an essential need for Industrialisation. Railways and the roads could not be developed sufficiently owing to a rugged terrain. The Amazon and the La Plata rivers, provide cheap water transport. In spite of having an abundance of natural resources, industrialisation started quite late in South America. Recently, new industries are being set up with locally available raw materials. Brazil is the most industrialized country in the continent followed by Argentina.

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